SATI
South African Translators' Institute

# Accreditation in Sworn Translation

# Prerequisites

You must be a current, paid-up SATI member. *(Student membership does not qualify.*)

**AND** any one of the following:

- Be currently accredited by SATI

**OR**

- Be a member of or currently accredited by a FIT member association acceptable to the SATI Council

**OR**

- Have a language practice qualification PLUS at least two years' language practice experience in general translating (with professional references)

**OR**

- Have at least five years' language practice experience in general translating (with professional references)

# Important information

If you want to become accredited for sworn translation, you must:

- Study the SATI sworn translation manual (2020 edition) first
- Write the practice test in sworn translation before applying for the exam
- Follow the conventions in the SATI sworn translation manual (2020 edition) to pass

Ideally, you should have a legal background or thorough knowledge of the legal systems relevant to the languages you are translating.

Once you pass the accreditation exam, you must be sworn in at the High Court of South Africa to complete the process. The court application procedure is explained in the SATI sworn translation manual (2020 edition).

# Practice test

This is a short test to give you an idea of what to expect in the exam.

After taking the test, you'll know:

- Whether your legal knowledge is sufficient to pass the accreditation exam
- Whether you understand how to certify and format the sworn translation and how to use translator's notes correctly

Writing the practice test is **compulsory**, but passing the test is **not** a guarantee that you will pass the exam.

# Differences between the practice test and the exam

| Practice Test | Examination |
|---|---|
| 1 text | 5 or 6 texts |
| 3 months' time limit | 24 hours |
| Marked by 1 examiner | Marked by 2 examiners |
| Get back your marked test paper with a report | Get back a summarised report |

# Marking of the practice test

In the practice test (one text), the following will constitute a fail:

- One major error plus three or more minor errors

  or

- Four or more minor errors

Candidates are penalised only once for major errors of a technical nature, such as failure to certify.

# Waiting periods

If you pass the practice test, you can apply to write the exam immediately.

If you fail the test, the following waiting periods will apply before you can write the exam in sworn translation:

- No major errors and 4 to 8 minor errors:  3 months
- No major errors and more than 8 minor errors: 6 months
- One major error and 0 to 4 minor errors: 6 months
- One major error and more than 4 minor errors: 8 months
- Two or more major errors: 8 months

# Preparing for the exam

The SATI exam in sworn translation is designed for candidates who are already experts and seasoned translators and would like to add SATI accreditation to their qualifications.

SATI has published a sworn translation manual (2020 edition) to help candidates prepare for the exam. SATI does not train translators.

# Venue and date

- You will agree on the exam date and time with the accreditation officer.
- When agreed, you will get the password-protected exam documents by email.
- You must complete and return the documents within 24 hours.
- You must complete a statement declaring that you have followed the rules of the exam.
- If you do not follow any of the exam conditions, the exam will be declared null and void and the exam fee will be forfeited. You will have to wait 12 months before you can apply to write the exam again.

# Documents

You'll be emailed the documents you must translate on the day of the exam.

You must translate all the texts.

Text types include academic certificates and transcripts, contracts, civil and personal documents (birth/death/divorce/marriage certificates), testimonials and wills.

The texts will be replicas of actual documents but should be treated as originals for the purposes of the exam.

# Tips – 1

When writing your exam, we recommend to:

- Read the instructions carefully
- Analyse each text for tone, register, style, emphasis, context
- Plan your time carefully
- Stick as closely as possible to the format of the original document
- Use a spellchecker
- Proofread carefully for typos, extra spacing and other odd formatting

# Tips – 2

Specifically, make sure to check the following:

- Proper names are spelled exactly as in the original (unless it is an obvious error, in which case a note must be added)
- Numbers are typed exactly as in the original (unless it is an obvious error, in which case a note must be added)
- No words on the page have been missed, including words that appear in the margins
- All stamps, signatures, logos, drawings, etc. have been annotated
- Each page has been correctly certified
- All pages have been numbered

# Resources – 1

The following resources are allowed and recommended when writing the test and exam:

- A spellchecker for the **target language** [If translating in English, always use English (UK)]
- Any dictionaries, glossaries, wordlists, reports, grammar guides, thesaurus and books on language
- Specifically for sworn translation, specialist legal dictionaries (monolingual and bilingual) are essential
- Internet resources for research and reference purposes

# Resources – 2

The test and exam must be your own work. You are not allowed to use the following:

- Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) tools such as ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini and Claude
- Machine translation tools such as Google Translate, DeepL and Microsoft Translator
- Any person, discussion group, forum, social media group or professional network that could help you with the translation
- Any tool or feature that helps you analyse, interpret, write, rewrite, summarise or translate the text

# Resources – 3

Examples of what **is allowed**:

- Looking up words or grammar rules in a dictionary or guide (online or hard copy)
- Looking up terminology in a glossary or terminology database
- Researching facts or background information using a search engine
- Using a spellchecker
- Using a proofreading or consistency-checking tool

Examples of what **is not allowed**:

- Asking other people for help with the translation
- Using a GenAI tool to write, rewrite, explain, summarise or improve text
- Using machine translation to translate any part of the source text
- Placing any part of the text into a GenAI tool or machine translation tool

# Assessment

The sworn translation exam is marked by two examiners. They do not have contact with each other, and they do not know the candidate's name.

These examiners are professional, experienced and accredited sworn translators.

# Error types

The following are considered MAJOR ERRORS:

- ***Gross mistranslation*** – where the meaning is lost completely
- ***Omission*** of vital information
- ***Insertion*** of information
- Including ***alternate translations*** (instead of making a choice)
- ***Failure in target language grammar*** (e.g. concord, tense, conjugation, prepositions, idiom)
- ***Misspelling names of persons or places or reference numbers***
- ***Miscopying*** dates or numbers
- ***Failure to certify at all***

# Error types

The following are considered MINOR ERRORS:

- ***Mistranslation*** – where the meaning is slightly distorted
- ***Omission*** of less important information
- ***Inelegant target language grammar*** (e.g. word order, spelling, punctuation)
- ***Typographical errors***
- ***Failure to certify every page***

# Failing

The following number of errors will result in a fail in the exam:

- Two or more major errors overall

  *or*

- Eight or more minor errors overall

  *or*

- One major error and three minor errors in one question

  *or*

- Four or more minor errors in one question

Candidates are penalised only once for major errors of a technical nature, such as failure to certify.

# Other

The following aspects are also considered:

- The target text must stand as a text in its own right.
- The target text must read like an original.
- The equivalent pass mark (e.g. in an academic exam) would be around 90%.

You are allowed to use **annotations** (footnotes) to communicate with the examiner, for instance to explain a particular decision. However, these should be used sparingly.

# Results

It can take up to **six weeks** to receive the result. You'll get a report with a selection of examiners' comments.

***Note:***

- Not all errors will be listed in the report.
- You will not see your marked script.
- You cannot discuss the result with the accreditation officer.

# Accreditation certification

If you pass:

- You will be emailed an accreditation certificate.
- You will be listed on SATI's website as an accredited member.
- You may advertise your accreditation status, e.g. in an email signature.

**Important**: Passing the exam does not make you a sworn translator. You must still arrange to appear before a judge at your closest High Court.

# Unsuccessful result

If you fail the exam, you may apply again after **one year**.

Please read the assessment comments carefully and follow the markers' advice.

# Appeal

If you want to appeal the result, you must submit the application form and proof of payment **within 8 weeks** of the date of the report.

Your original exam script will be marked by a third examiner.
Their decision will be final. There will be no more discussion after the second round of marking.

If the ‘Fail’ result is overturned, you will be refunded for the appeal and will be given accreditation status.

# Accreditation validity

Accreditation remains valid for as long as you are a member of SATI.

It's very important to understand that if you let your membership lapse, even for one year, **you will lose your accreditation**.

If you want to become accredited again, you will have to re-apply in terms of the SATI policy on reinstatement of accreditation.
Contact the SATI office for more information.

For more information, please email SATI's accreditation officer:

accreditation@translators.org.za

SATI

Your language is our language